VIT BHOPAL

CSE0001 - DIGITAL LITERACY

PROJECT REPORT

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Introduction

This Digital Literacy Project serves as a comprehensive exploration of the essential skills required to navigate, create and communicate safely in the modern professional world. This project helps to bridge the gap between technical proficiency and responsible digital citizenship. The project spans five critical areas: from establishing a professional identity on platforms like GitHub and LinkedIn and mastering formal email etiquette, to analyzing the complex mechanics of UPI-based social engineering scams and maintaining a positive digital footprint. By combining practical coding challenges with deep dives into cybersecurity and online safety, this project demonstrates a holistic commitment to understanding how technology, ethics, and security intersect in our daily lives.

Task - 1 : Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

The infographic I made, titled "Building a Safer Online Space," provides a visually engaging guide to the core principles of digital literacy and internet safety. The design is structured into four key pillars: defining digital literacy as the ability to understand technology, evaluate information, and engage in digital creation. It emphasizes the importance of "thinking before you share" to protect personal information, the infographic also suggests some useful digital tools like note-taking and summary-making apps for students and outlining critical safe internet practices such as using strong passwords, managing privacy settings, and recognizing phishing.

One of the most interesting aspects of creating this design in Canva was finding the right balance between the vibrant, modern aesthetic and the clarity of the educational message.

I personally enjoyed the editing process without much difficulty as I use canva often for personal and professional purposes, the most engaging part of this task was the "Digital Creation" phase itself—selecting a color palette that feels professional yet tech-savvy and using visual hierarchy to ensure that each section, from "Safe Internet Practices" to "Useful Digital Tools," is easily digestible for the reader.

Task - 2 : Build Your Student Digital Portfolio

For the "Build Your Student Digital Portfolio" task, I established a professional online presence by creating and optimizing profiles on GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle. This task focused on bridging the gap between academic learning and industry expectations, allowing me to document my growth as a Computer Science and Engineering student.

Each platform serves a distinct purpose in my professional development:

- GitHub: This serves as a version-control repository where I can host my coding projects, showcase my proficiency in Python, and demonstrate my commitment to mastering data structures and algorithms.
- LinkedIn: I use this as a professional networking hub to connect with industry leaders, share project

milestones, and express my interest in fields like GenAI, Machine Learning, and Natural Language Processing

- Kaggle: This platform allows me to engage with the data science community, participate in predictive modeling challenges, and build a portfolio of work related to intelligent systems.

Over the next four years, I plan to use these platforms as a dynamic record of my evolution from a fresher to a professional engineer. I will use GitHub to consistently commit code for increasingly complex software projects, LinkedIn to build a strategic network and seek internship opportunities like those in NLP and AI and Kaggle to sharpen my analytical skills through real-world datasets. Together, these platforms will ensure my digital footprint remains professional, credible, and aligned with my goal of mastering high-level technologies.

Task - 3 : Explore Coding & Collaboration Platforms

For the "Explore Coding & Collaboration Platforms" task, I focused on enhancing my technical problem-solving abilities while simultaneously engaging with the community to measure digital awareness. I used platforms such as HackerRank and Google Forms in this task. This task involved mastering algorithmic challenges on HackerRank and designing a comprehensive assessment tool using Google Forms to evaluate public digital literacy.

Solving the "Solve Me First" problem on HackerRank was a pivotal moment in building my technical confidence, as it allowed me to successfully implement a functional Python 3 solution and verify it against multiple test cases. This practice was instrumental in sharpening my Python syntax and logic-building skills, providing a solid foundation for tackling more complex data structures in the future.

Transitioning from coding to community assessment, I developed a "Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz" that utilized both multiple-choice and short-answer questions to gauge public understanding of critical topics like Two-Factor Authentication (2FA) and digital footprints. Analyzing these responses provided valuable insights into common security misconceptions and the general public's readiness for digital challenges.

Academically, these tasks are highly beneficial as they bridge the gap between theoretical knowledge and practical application. Mastering platforms like HackerRank prepares me for technical interviews and competitive programming, while using Google Workspace for collaboration and data collection enhances my ability to conduct research and analyze social trends—skills that are essential for any aspiring Computer Science engineer.

Task - 4 : Draft a Professional Email & Etiquette Guide

In the "Draft a Professional Email & Etiquette Guide" task, I developed practical communication skills by drafting two distinct professional emails and a social media safety checklist. The first email was a formal request to a professor for an assignment extension due to medical reasons, while the second was a targeted inquiry to a hiring manager regarding a summer internship in Natural Language Processing. To complement these, I created a "Do's and Don'ts" checklist for college students, emphasizing the importance of reviewing privacy settings and passing the "Billboard Test" to maintain a positive digital footprint. Learning to draft a professional email gave me confidence to write a concised yet to the point mail in a formal scenario and the knowledge I gained while creating the checklist, would help me remember and excecute in my day-to-day life as an active social media user in youth.

Hypothetical Scenario: The Cost of Poor Digital Communication

A student, frustrated by a challenging mid-term exam, posted a heated "cyber-vent" on a public social media platform, calling their professor "incompetent" and "unfair." Months later, while applying for a high-stakes internship, the recruiter conducted a routine background check and found the archived post. Despite the student's strong technical resume, the recruiter retracted the interview offer, fearing the student lacked the professional maturity and emotional intelligence required for their corporate culture.

What could have been done differently:

- Applied the "Billboard Test": Before posting, the student should have asked themselves if they would be comfortable with that statement being displayed on a giant billboard in the center of campus

- Private Conflict Resolution: Instead of "cyber-venting" publicly, the student could have used their professional email skills to draft a respectful message to the professor or a department head to discuss their concerns through proper academic channels.

- Active Digital Footprint Management: The student should have regularly audited their privacy settings to ensure that past emotional outbursts or controversial interactions were not visible to future recruiters.

Task - 5 : Cybercrime Awareness Case Study & Prevention Guide

In the "Cybercrime Awareness Case Study & Prevention Guide" task, I conducted an in-depth analysis of modern digital fraud, specifically focusing on the UPI "Collect Request" and QR code scams prevalent in India. My research involved analyzing the step-by-step anatomy of these crimes—from the initial "lure," where scammers often pose as trustworthy figures like army officers, to the "technical switch" where victims are tricked into entering their UPI PIN to "receive" money. To provide a practical solution, I supplemented this case study with an "Online Safety Checklist" by doing some internet research and taking insights from elderly as well as youth on their personal experience of tackling internet frauds and some tips received to safeguard ourselves from such incidents and compiled them into a short checklist.

What surprised me most during this research was the sophisticated use of "social engineering" as a primary bait for commoners. It was eye-opening to see how scammers don't just rely on hacking code, but instead build intense urgency and false trust to manipulate a victim's behavior, leading them to bypass their own common sense. It shows how even a ‘tech-savvy’ person could fall bait to this issue if one doesnt have required current knowledge of happenings in society or adequate critical thinking.

As a direct result of the insights gained from this project, one habit I have personally committed to changing is my level of caution during digital transactions.I have learned to never enter a UPI PIN or scan a QR code when expecting to receive money, as a PIN is strictly for authorizing outgoing payments.

Conclusion

This Digital Literacy project has provided a comprehensive foundation in navigating the modern digital ecosystem through six key pillars. By building a professional student portfolio on GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle, I established a strategic digital identity focused on AI and Machine Learning. I enhanced my technical and collaborative skills by solving algorithmic challenges on HackerRank using Python and conducting a Google Forms-based public literacy assessment. My work on professional email etiquette and a social media checklist, guided by the "Billboard Test", emphasized the importance of maintaining a positive digital footprint and clear communication. Through an in-depth cybercrime case study, I analyzed the psychological tactics behind UPI and QR scams, which significantly heightened my security awareness. Finally, I applied my creative design skills in Canva to synthesize these concepts into an educational infographic. Collectively, these tasks have equipped me with the critical thinking and technical tools necessary for responsible digital citizenship.

References

Task	Tool/Platform	URL
Task 1	Canva (Infographics)	canva.com
Task 2	GitHub	github.com
Task 2	LinkedIn	linkedin.com
Task 2	Kaggle	kaggle.com
Task 3	HackerRank	hackerrank.com
Task 3	Google Forms	forms.google.com
Task 5	Cyber Crime Portal	cybercrime.gov.in
Task 5	Cyber Crime Helpline	1930 (24x7 phone)